

FRIDAY

FOCUS ON: Paul, the Apostle

READ TOGETHER: Philippians 4:1-13

ANCHORED BY GRATITUDE

Rejoice in the Lord always. Again I will say, rejoice! (Philippians 4:4)

FOR FAMILY WORSHIP: Pages 42-44

FURTHER STUDY FOR PARENTS: Pages 45-47

DEVOTIONAL

THE UNSHAKABLE JOY OF GRATITUDE

Imagine the prison after sunset. Outside, the sky is losing its last colors, but inside Paul's cell the dark comes early. The floor is cold, his wrist is chained, keys clink down the hall, and Paul cannot open the door. Still, from that hard place, he writes a bright sentence: "Rejoice in the Lord always. Again I will say, rejoice!" (Philippians 4:4).

Paul is not pretending prison is fun. He is not saying chains do not hurt or lonely nights are easy. His joy is braver than a pretend smile. Paul remembers that God stayed near in storms, danger, rejection, and fear. Because he remembers God's goodness, his heart can still sing.

This is where gratitude teaches priority management. Priority management means choosing what gets the first chair in your day. It is like putting the biggest rock in the jar first, before the tiny pebbles. For a child, it means

asking, "What matters most right now?" God first. Love first. People before screens. Thankfulness before complaining. When the important things go first, the noisy things do not get to boss the whole day.

In a **VUCA WORLD**, plans can shake, tomorrow can feel uncertain, choices can feel tangled, and messages can make things blurry. Screens often say, "Want more. Compare more. Prove more. Scroll more." Gratitude stops the noise and whispers, "Look again. God is here."

So picture Paul lifting his chained hands. Not because the chains are good, but because God is good. Not because the cell is comfortable, but because grace has not left the room. Gratitude does not erase hard days; it helps us see God inside them.

Joy grows where gratitude is practiced. When we begin with the Lord, even a difficult day can become a place where His goodness is easier to see.

READ

ASK

FAMILY PRAYER

Name a way God cared for us today. Then pray together: **"Dear God, help us notice Your goodness and rejoice with thankful hearts. In Jesus' name, amen."**

Paul's experience was the most difficult:

VOLATILE: Paul was chased and jailed.

UNCERTAIN: Paul might not come home.

COMPLEX: Young churches felt pushed around.

AMBIGUOUS: Can joy grow in trouble?

And even then, Paul trusted God to change it:

VENTURE: Choose joy even when life hurts.

UNVEIL: See God's gifts today.

COMPASS: Let gratitude guide your heart.

ASSURANCE: Use screens to bless others.

Paul did not escape every hardship, but he learned where to place his focus. In a **VUCA WORLD**, gratitude helps us notice God's goodness, bless others rather than compare, and live with a freer heart

1 Read
Philippians 4:4
and 4:11.

2 Underline
the words
"**always**" or
"**be content**"

3 Ask yourself:

- What feelings do screens grow on me?
- Does my screen time grow thankfulness?

Paul helps us by showing that even in a hard place, God can grow a thankful heart. **I promise we will look for God's gifts together and use our screens to share kindness, not compare.**

FAMILY ACTIVITY: The Blessing Flashlight

Place a flashlight on the table and say, "Screens can help us compare, complain, or bless. Today, we choose blessing." Turn on the flashlight and pass it around. Each person answers: "Thank You, God, for...", "I want to encourage...", and "One kind thing I can say online is..." Then ask together: **Did my words shine love or comparison?**



FURTHER STUDY FOR PARENTS:

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Today's Principle:
Gratitude Forms Purpose

Today's Promise for your home is grateful and free:
Screens can share blessings, not stir comparison today.

Paul's prison letter invites parents to practice gratitude as a brave family habit. In a noisy digital world, thankfulness trains the heart to notice God's gifts, resist comparison, and use screens to bless others with steadier joy, purpose, and peace.

V VENTURE BEYOND FEAR IN A VOLATILE WORLD

Paul teaches parents that gratitude is not born from easy days. It is born when the heart learns where to look. He faced pressure, danger, prison, and an uncertain future, yet he could still say, "Rejoice in the Lord always" and "I have learned...to be content" (Philippians 4:4, 11).

This does not mean Paul ignored pain. He did not pretend the chains were soft or the prison was pleasant. Gratitude did not erase his trouble; it trained his mind to remember God in the middle of trouble.

Parents need this same grace in a **VUCA WORLD**. Home can quickly become a place of complaints, comparison, and digital noise. But when a parent practices gratitude, the child learns to notice blessings, not only problems. A grateful home does not say, "Everything is perfect." It says, "God is still good."

ASK YOURSELF: IS MY MIND MORE TRAINED IN COMPLAINING OR IN GRATITUDE?

U UNVEIL DEEPER TRUTH IN UNCERTAIN TIMES

Read Philippians 4:4 and 4:11. Underline always and content. Then ask: What feelings do my screens grow in me? Do I compare my family, life, home, or blessings with others? Do my feeds teach gratitude, or do they make my heart want more and more?

Screens can pull our eyes toward what is missing, like a window showing everyone else's toys. Gratitude gently turns our eyes toward what God has already placed in our hands.

PAUL TEACHES US THAT PEACE IS NOT CONTROLLED BY THE ROOM WE ARE IN, BUT BY THE DIRECTION OF OUR HEART. A PRISON CELL COULD NOT STEAL HIS JOY, BECAUSE HIS FOCUS WAS FIXED ON GOD.

C COMPASS THAT REMAINS STEADY THROUGH COMPLEXITY

Gratitude helps a family live from what God has placed in their hands, not only from what feels missing. This is an educational principle from Ellen White, because gratitude is not just teaching a child to say "thank you." It is teaching the heart how to see life. Ellen White wrote, ***"Nothing tends more to promote health of body and of soul than does a spirit of gratitude and praise"*** (The Ministry of Healing, p. 251). In the home, gratitude becomes a gentle teacher. It helps parents and children notice care, provision, forgiveness, beauty, and signs of God's love.

This matters because family life can be busy and tiring. Parents may be doing their best while feeling stretched. Children may feel the pull of screens, ads, and comparison. Digital culture whispers, "You need more. Others have more. You are not enough." Gratitude answers with a better message: "Look what God has given. Look who loves you. Look how you can bless someone today."

Gratitude trains the family's gaze. Instead of only seeing the toy that is missing, the trip someone else took, or the perfect picture another family posted, a grateful home learns to see the warm meal, the answered prayer, the safe hug, and the strength God gave for one more day. This does not deny hard things. It helps the heart stand in a healthier place while facing them.

When gratitude grows, screen use can change too. We do not post to prove our worth. We do not scroll to fill an empty heart. We do not compare our family story with someone else's best moment. We can use technology to say thank you, encourage a friend, share hope, and bless others.

In a **VUCA WORLD**, gratitude becomes a compass for the home. It turns the family's wanting into a joyful purpose.

A GRATEFUL HOME DOES NOT REVOLVE AROUND WHAT IS MISSING; IT GROWS AROUND GOD'S GIFTS AND BECOMES READY TO GIVE.

A ASSURANCE THAT STANDS FIRM AMID AMBIGUITY

Now live gratitude with a simple parent practice called **THE BLESSING CHECK-IN**. For three days, before using social media or sending family messages, mother and father take one quiet minute together. Each chooses one grateful message to send, one public word that honors someone without showing off, and one private note that encourages a person who may need kindness.

If only one parent is present, do it with another trusted adult or prayerfully on your own. During these days, avoid complaints, comparisons, and indirect comments. Let your screen become a small window of grace, not a mirror of comparison.

BEFORE YOU POST OR REPLY, PAUSE AND ASK: WILL MY WORDS BLESS OR BRUISE?



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Would my digital history show gratitude or criticism? In a **VUCA WORLD**, grace helps my family use screens to multiply blessings and live with lighter, thankful hearts today.